

■ Pranab Mukherjee FINANCE MINISTER THE ARTFUL NEGOTIATOR

The man who could not be the President of India in 2007 because he was considered too indispensable to pension off is still doing what he does best: firefighting for the UPA. Just recently during a Cabinet Committee on Infrastructure meet, Railway Minister Mamata Banerjee took the prime minister by surprise when she wanted approval for 24 rail projects estimated at Rs 15,000 crore. Since she had got this listed on the Cabinet agenda the night before, Manmohan was not amused at this last minute demand for funds and looked towards Pranab Mukherjee. Taking the cue, Mukherjee told Banerjee that "this is not the way the Government functions". Unnerved by his reprimand, Banerjee burst into tears as another Cabinet colleague Kumari Selja rushed to hug her. An unfazed Mukherjee then used the occasion to educate Banerjee on coalition economics pointing out that since she was the first to oppose economic reforms, how could she then expect the Government to raise money for her populist projects?

Balancing coalition compulsion with the demands of mercurial allies is all part of Pranab's unofficial portfolio as the Government's troubleshooter in-chief, whether it is placating Banerjee on the UPA's land acquisition policies or the DMK on disinvestment. So indispensable is he that the prime minister once postponed a Cabinet meet to discuss the price rise simply because Mukherjee's meeting with the visiting Bangladesh Prime Minister Sheikh Hasina Wajed got delayed. And when senior ministers like S.M. Krishna and Shashi Tharoor got into a controversy over their five-star residences, it was again Mukherjee who gave them a dressing down on the prime minister's behalf.

When Parliament is in session, it is Mukherjee's Room 13 that ends up with the hottest tea bill with MPs, cutting across all party lines, dropping in for

advice. What works is his own stature, both within the Congress and outside, that gives him the authority to cajole and reprimand troublemakers. And as the finance minister, Mukherjee's own socialist credentials give a ring of sincerity to Manmohan's words when he expresses concern for the *aam aadmi*.

■ P. Chidambaram HOME MINISTER THE LAST ACTION HERO

Recently when quizzed whether there was a greater role in store for him in the Government, P. Chidambaram replied that he was actually "looking for a much smaller role" for himself. Humility best becomes those who have little to be humble about and the home minister knows all too well how indispensable he has become. Finally, there is a strong home minister in North Block, a man whose image bolsters Manmohan's credibility when he talks about being strong on terror. Whether it is Naxals, Telangana or the controversial Indo-Pak talks, each of these has Chidambaram as the chief crisis manager. When the decision came to replace Shivraj Patil at the Home Ministry, Chidambaram was the first choice of both Sonia Gandhi and Manmohan. He delivered 400 days of peace as opposed to the blast-every-other-month regime of Patil. Even after the Pune blasts such is his credibility

that there have been no negative reports about intelligence failure except for the usual Opposition attack.

Which is why when the Harvard educated, ace lawyer-turned-home minister proposed a radical restructuring of the internal security architecture, Manmohan promptly agreed. Even when Chidambaram was the finance minister, the two were on the same page of economic reforms, despite the many turf wars between the Harvard White and the Oxford Blues (the Montek Singh Ahluwalia-Manmohan duo). Now, of course, with Chidambaram handling home—with Manmohan's somewhat grateful support—there is little scope for a turf war. In fact this harmony between the North and South Block is unprecedented as these two centres of power have always clashed ever since Jawaharlal Nehru was prime minister and Sardar Patel ruled the Home Ministry.

■ Sharad Pawar AGRICULTURE MINISTER THE GAME CHANGER

It is the most unlikely of friendships, between an apolitical Congress prime minister and the politically shrewd NCP chief. Their camaraderie dates back to 1991 when Sharad Pawar was the staunchest defender of the then finance minister's economic policies. As NCP leader Praful Patel points out, "the two are on



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